did not share his faith. Many Hindus feel the same way; I am vegetarian myself, and abhor the idea of consuming the corpses of animals, but I do not judge those who, for cultural or other personal reasons, do so. I only ask that animals be treated decently and without cruelty, and that even their slaughter, for purposes of consumption, be conducted humanely and with minimal pain and suffering for the poor creatures.

The furore that accompanied the new Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act (Regulation of Livestock Markets) Rules, 2016, rolled out by the Ministry of Environmental Affairs in Delhi, polarised opinion across the country, especially in beef-eating states like Kerala. There it produced a strong reaction from an indignant chief minister, invited condemnation across the local political spectrum, forced the state to drag the centre to court, united warring student union factions to organise beef festivals across the state and even gave Twitizens a field day with #PoMoneModi (Go Away Modi), used last when the PM compared Kerala to the African nation of Somalia, resurfacing as a popular hashtag.[37]

Though the new rules do not directly impose a beef ban, they contrive to make cow slaughter all but impossible through the back door, by making it impossible to transport or sell cattle for slaughter. In the process, they have raised fundamental questions the government cannot escape, even as it tried to shift the focus to the misbehaviour of a few young men who misguidedly slaughtered a calf in public as a form of protest.

The first issue is constitutional—the decision to institute the full prohibition of cow slaughter is a prerogative of the states, not the government at the centre. Entry 15 of the State List of the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution provides for the ‘Preservation, protection and improvement of stock and prevention of animal diseases, veterinary training and practice’, empowering the state legislatures to legislate the prevention of slaughter and preservation of cattle. Different states have different approaches to cow welfare. Some states like Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Delhi have strict laws while others such as Kerala, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Manipur, Mizoram and Nagaland have milder rules or no rules governing the welfare of cows. The blanket new rule is